Anniversary

By Conrad Bishop

Takes place in the present in the home of a sophisticated young couple celebrating their first anniversary.

INTRODUCTION

WOMAN: *Today, half of all marriages end in divorce, and only half of those that endure are truly happy in the long run.*

MAN: *Pre-marriage counseling is based on the reality that it's important to strengthen your relationship and prepare constructively for future challenges and conflicts that everyone will inevitably face at some point.*

WOMAN: *Research shows that there is a window of opportunity during the year before the wedding and the six months or so after when couples get the optimum benefit from marriage counseling.*

MAN: *Later, under stress, negative habits and relationship patterns may become established and be much harder to resolve.*

WOMAN: *For instance . . .how many couples would think to resolve the issue of who takes out the garbage before it leads to divorce?*

TOGETHER: *Anniversary by Conrad Bishop*

MAN: **(Pg 6-12)** Terrific meal

WOMAN: For a terrific couple.

MAN: Happy anniversary, honey.

WOMAN: The first of many.

MAN: Many happy returns.

WOMAN: Speaking of returns, do you want to look at the bills?

MAN: This is our anniversary, honey.

WOMAN: There's a final notice.

MAN: Yeh, but. . .

WOMAN: I'll put them on the desk.

MAN: So many things have happened in one year. So many adjustments.

WOMAN: Adjusting, learning to give and take. . .

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MAN: Take charge of our lives, face up to our problems and solve them.

WOMAN: And now that we've solved them, it should really be nice.

MAN: Because it has been kind of rough, you know. . .

WOMAN: Well sure, it's hard to grow. We've grown personally.

MAN: We have. Like our quarrels have grown... I mean they've matured.

WOMAN: Our anger, we've learned how to deal with it. That magazine article. . .

MAN: "Have Fun with Your Anger."

WOMAN: And you know, when we have kids, I am never going to be angry with them. It's just not necessary. If you love them and raise them the right way, they'll never cause you problems.

MAN: Not many couples could say on their first anniversary that they have solved all their significant problems.

WOMAN: But it's true.

MAN: I think we're way ahead of most couples. Maybe five years ahead of most.

WOMAN: Happy anniversary, honey. *(They kiss and turn front)* Our marriage, well it's hard to talk about because it really has been this incredible experience. . .

MAN: Incredible but believable. We're more than just married. We're good friends.

WOMAN: Friends, of course we're more than just friends. It's so stimulating, so liberating... I've been liberated to do so much. New furniture, new colors, new recipes. . .

MAN: Zulu cookery. We have so many tastes in common. Even colors. Now the brighter end of the chartreuse scale is not often. . .

WOMAN: It's not often found so early in a marriage.

MAN: Really incredible. *(They turn to one another)*

WOMAN: Honey, before it gets too late and we get involved in something else, could you take out the garbage?

MAN: Huh?

WOMAN: Would you take out the garbage? It's kind of piled up.

MAN: Honey. . . you're gonna laugh.

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WOMAN: What?

MAN: The garbage. I just can't cope with the garbage.

WOMAN: Oh. Well, as long as it's out before breakfast.

MAN: No. I don't mean garbage now. I mean garbage always. Garbage forever.

WOMAN: But we agreed: garbage is your province. Do you think we're making too much garbage, is that it?

MAN: It's not a recycling question, or a question of less garbage or better garbage. It's the fact of garbage.

WOMAN: Well, it's a human fact. We all generate refuse. If you put two people together. . .

MAN: That's it. That's it. This is our product. Our love, our sensitivity, our relationship results in this. . . horrible accumulation. Oh, I know it's a petty little thing, but. . .

WOMAN: It's not petty. There are three sacks of it. Honey, this is our anniversary. I would like it to be a garbage-free anniversary.

MAN: And how can we really, truly say Happy Anniversary when there is this external manifestation of our relationship bulging across the kitchen at us? The Johnsons? Two doors down? He goes out once a week with a little plastic thing. It doesn't look like garbage, it doesn't smell like garbage. It's an intense but comprehensible concentration of semi-organic substance, like the Johnsons. But ours. . .

WOMAN: I don't understand.

MAN: Take out the garbage. Please. You take out the garbage

WOMAN: I could take out the garbage. But I think there's something more basic here.

MAN: Honey...

WOMAN: Why do you want to give me the garbage when you hate it so much?

MAN: I'm not giving it to you.

WOMAN: I just don't like the idea of having it thrust into my hands.

MAN: I'm not thrusting.

WOMAN: You are thrusting.

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MAN: Why do you use these masculine images? I'm not trying to thrust it, I'm trying to . . . share it! . . . You've never had the freedom to take out the garbage, and I want that experience for you

WOMAN: Well. . . thank. . . you. . . *(They turn front)* It is a dilemma, of course, not that it can't be worked out. I have a great concern for the garbage, just as much as Chris does, because it seems to have this place of importance in our lives. . .

MAN: It's a kind of focal point for a lot of things, and maybe if we can just focus on the focal point, things will come more into focus.

WOMAN: Because very often, in terms of taking responsibility, Chris has a tendency to . . . give it to me. And we thought perhaps we should work this out the way we work things out. He would state what he feels and I would state what I feel. Which we did. I stated that the garbage needs taking out.

MAN: And I agreed. But I stated that I had a very negative reaction to her tone of voice in stating her statement.

WOMAN: So I tried to find a better tone of voice in which to state the needs of the garbage, in order to strike a better balance between Chris's needs and those of the garbage. I tried a plain old "Take out the garbage."

MAN: That's very blunt.

WOMAN: OK. "Honey, I wonder if I might ask you to expel the garbage?"

MAN: It rings false.

WOMAN: OK. "Sweetheart. Dearest. I know you don't like to, because there's a lot on your mind such as solving the nation's balance of payments and also paying our bills, but I really don't know where to put any more garbage. Should I pile it in the bathroom or the closets, or put it in the bed as a helpful hint, or serve it again for dinner? Or maybe we could sleep in the garage and use the house for the garbage but could you please take it out?"

MAN: I hate attempts at humor.

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WOMAN: "Oh, look at this! It's the garbage! It would be so much fun to do something with this! But I need a big strong man to do it! And everyone will look out their window and say, "What a big strong man going down those stairs! Doesn't he take good care of her garbage!"

MAN: She really misses the whole point.

WOMAN: "Hey baby, haul my garbage!" . . . Not to take away from our anniversary.

MAN: Because it really is a very happy anniversary, really. . .

WOMAN: Really, really, really incredible. *(They turn to one another, and start to laugh)*

MAN: I don't know how we got into this.

WOMAN: Neither do I.

MAN: I mean I don't think it's really a problem. It's just a new aspect of our relationship.

WOMAN: Though it is an aspect that's beginning to pile up.

MAN: Look, I'm not trying to shove it under the rug.

WOMAN: No way, no way. Let's put it out in the middle of the rug. Some people have potted plants, we'll have canned fungus. The mold will just match the color scheme. . . Go on. Say something.

MAN: No.

WOMAN: Don't repress it.

MAN: I have to repress it.

WOMAN: You don't have to repress it.

MAN: You make me repress it.

WOMAN: I just said it: Don't repress it. Don't repress it.

MAN: But your attitude is repress it, repress it.

WOMAN: OK then, repress it! Only repress it better!

MAN: Look, we both know that in order to be resolved this has to come out some way, and not destructively, of course, but in a constructive way that will bring us closer together. . .

WOMAN: OK then do it! Do it! Do it!

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MAN: OK. OK. OK. I'm sick of it all and it has nothing to do with the garbage. It's you and the job and the marriage. I want to throw up. I want to break every window in this mousetrap house. I want to get in the car and take off ninety miles an hour to California and forget I ever got in this because I can't stand the thought of fifty more years of ~he same damn thing. I want to give all the wedding presents to Goodwill and you come at me with this earnest little mousy sarcastic whine and patch it up with one sincere conversation a week and we make a list that we lose under all the garbage. We spew out day and night and I'm sick of it all! . . . Wow. I feel better.

WOMAN: You do.

MAN: Yes. I feel good. Do you feel good?

WOMAN: No.

MAN: We have a better understanding.

WOMAN: Can I react to that?

MAN: I don't need a reaction.

WOMAN: You. . . insensitive. . . insincere. . . insecure. . . immature. . . *(Phone rings)*

MAN: Telephone.

WOMAN: *(She answers it. Total change of tone)* Hello? . . . Linda, hi! Oh nothing, just celebrating our anniversary. Talking things over, making plans.

MAN: Tell her about the house.

WOMAN: We looked at a new house. It's incredible! Big lawn, carpets, all electric... George wants to say Happy Anniversary.

MAN: . . . Yeh, made it through the first. Fifty more to go. Yeh, incredible. Everything is incredible. Appreciate it. Yeh. Bye. *(Hangs up. Silence)*

WOMAN: Nice of them to call.

MAN: We called them on theirs. *(Long silence)* When do you want to see the lawyer?

WOMAN: I'll call Monday. . .

MAN: You use ours. I'll find a new one.

WOMAN: Everything should be fifty-fifty.

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MAN: Even the garbage.

WOMAN: It's good we can be mature about things.

MAN: Make a rational judgment before we get. . . too involved.

WOMAN: You want me to pack you something?

MAN: No, I'll stop by tomorrow.

WOMAN: You know, I think we still are way, way ahead. A lot of couples, it takes, oh, six or seven years before they split. We've saved all those years.

MAN: I wonder what would happen. . . if one of us . . . sort of. . .

WOMAN: Gave in? Compromised?

MAN: Probably. . . set a bad precedent. . . Well, happy. . .

WOMAN: Yes. . . happy. . . *(They shake hands. Silence)*

MAN: Incredible.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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